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experience from which we learn need not be conscious at the time when we experience it.

Experience, then, is wider than conscious awareness but it cannot be wider than being itself – but the pre-conscious is clearly a significant aspect of our biography.

Part 2: Experience as biography

In my own definition of learning, which was discussed in Chapter 1, I suggest that the outcome of every learning event is built into our biographies, although these need not only be our cognitions (see OECD, 2007a), as our definition makes clear. In this sense we are learned persons, but we see from the discussion in the first part of this chapter that memory itself has evolved and that memory itself frees us from the immediate experience and yet in a complex manner it is a working memory that enables us to recall past experiences as and when they become relevant. Consequently, when we exclaim: 'In all my experience …' we are really talking of all the learning events that have made us what we are at that moment in time. Biography is the sum of those experiences from which we have learned and we are the product of those experiences. It is no accident that the influential Faure Report (1972) was called *Learning to Be*.

Our biographies are our understanding about ourselves as we pass through time. Time, however, forms a major problem when we consider experience; Rose (2006: 394) remarks that more 'needs to be done on this baffling problem' and we will look briefly at one aspect of this in the next part of this chapter. Relating time to consciousness Rose (ibid.: 394) says that all higher levels of consciousness are formed by binding between:

1 current input representations, short-term records and current motor efference (something that conducts outwards from the centre) to give retention or protention of the phenomenologists' 'thickness' of experience;
2 various durations of long-term memory … to generate conscious awareness of identity and meaning of a stimulus; and
3 long-term autobiographical memory and long-term plans, desires and life goals … our memories of the most significant evens so far, and imagined goals of what we want to reach in the future – to give us a sense of who we are and our sense of self.

Consequently, we can see that for as long as we are alive we are compiling our autobiography through experience and learning, and that we are always becoming (see Chapter 17) as we move from experience to experience or even from social status to social status. Phenomenology can be placed within this context since it is a process of 'binding across time to form systematic structures connecting memory, current inflow and plans for the future' (Rose, 2006: 395).

This process is clearly shown in the anthropological studies of van Gennep (1960 [1908]) and V. Turner (1969). More recently, and from a specifically learning perspective, Camilleri (2009) demonstrated this when she followed 10 nursing students through their final year in university and their first 18 months of practice. She showed quite convincingly that it was the experiences in the work place, above all, that provided the basis for the incidental and often pre-conscious learning that led to the students going through the process of playing the role of nurse and being identified as nurses by patients and others to actually identifying with the role, feeling that they were nurses and so eventually they actually became nurses in their own minds. At some stage in their careers they become a nurse – they gain a self-identity as a result of their experiences – in which they identify themselves with the social identity that wearing the uniform generated.

It is not surprising, therefore, that there has grown up in research into human learning the whole field of life history: individuals tracing their life histories and engaging in a process of learning from the experiences of life that they can

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remember them (see, for instance, West, 1996, 2001, 2007). Noonan (2003: 9) refers to this as 'experience-memory' in order to separate it from the process of memorising: memory of past experiences is quite fundamental to the process of identity building, which is at the heart of our biography.

It is through the process of living and learning that we gain wisdom, as Aristotle (1925: VI.8, 148) noted. Wisdom is the result of experience rather than being a science, like mathematics, that the young can master. Wisdom comes from the practical rather than the theoretical. Ageing also is clearly related to experience as biography and, as we live in an ageing society, it is not surprising that educational gerontology is emerging as a very significant area of study: how older people learn, utilise their learning and also how they feel isolated in a very rapidly changing society since it is hard to keep abreast with everything that is changing. Significantly, however, wisdom is one of the concepts that appears to play a less significant role as our work-orientated society concentrates on technical rationality and competence – knowledge of the present. Wisdom, however, is gained pre-consciously and incidentally in the process of living and learning from experience: it is tacit. Like wisdom, another concept that has not been fully studied in recent years has been the one with which it may be coupled – expertise – and we will turn to this shortly. However, we have to recognise that not all become wise as a result of living because there are many times when we fail to learn from our experiences – we presume upon them and take them for granted. Non-learning from experience is something quite vital to our understanding of learning (Jarvis, 1987), although there may be tacit changes in our understanding of ourselves as a result of this process.

Part 3: Experience as episode/event

In my previous work I did not separate these two terms. Following Donald (2001), I now think that this was a serious mistake, and much of my work has been based on events, which I called episodes, although episodes are actually series of events bound together in conscious awareness of their unity. It is, however, a major flaw in those evolutionary psychologists who consider that the brain is hard-wired as a result of our evolution and that we are programmed by our past to respond to stimuli in specific ways and at specific times. Donald argues that this flaw is exhibited by some of those scholars who believe that they are constructing a science of learning (OECD, 2007b: 11) and consider that our brains are fully wired at birth: scientists can claim that our brains are hard-wired based upon experiments that are no longer than a single event but not for those which span a whole episode, or sequence of events. Laboratory experiments can be carefully designed to record the here and now – they study sensations and very short-term memory – but these are not the limits of consciousness: this has 'a much larger window of experience than short-term memory' (Donald, 2001: 47). We can have an experience of a whole class or even a whole course – experience is an episode in our lives. The capacity of our brains is much larger than that required for the consciousness of a single sensation. We continue to be aware of the situation for a much longer period of time than the immediate and we hold it in our working memory for as long as necessary. No brain can be programmed to respond to a whole episode and this undermines a great deal of the theory of the hard-wired brain. It is what Schutz and Luckmann (1974: 51) called 'a stream of consciousness': experience is a sequence of events that overlap and form a continuous whole and yet, like biography, it is a single episode in our lives.

We sometimes live in the flow of time, an episode in which we seem to have heightened awareness all the time

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